

# Will AI Replace Lawyers?

The complete profile — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, the honest downsides, and what to ask before you commit.

4.5

AI EXPOSURE · TRIAL LITIGATOR / ADVOCACY

where 10 is most at risk

Read this one first; send the student version to them.



## Before you read this — a note for parents

You're likely reading this before your child is. That's normal, and it's worth pausing on how you use it.

**Don't lead with the scores.** If you open the conversation with a risk number, one of two things happens: they get frightened and shut down, or they get defensive about a decision they've already made. Neither produces a better choice.

The better approach: read this yourself first, then share it with them as *information you both get to react to*, not as a verdict you've reached. The discussion questions at the end are designed to be worked through together — they answer, you answer, you compare.

**What this is.** This is a facts document, not a recommendation. We've set out what's known, where the evidence is contested, where we might be wrong, and what the profession itself says — including the parts that don't support our own conclusions. What it deliberately doesn't do is tell your child what to choose.

### Three things to keep in mind:

1. **They're choosing, not you.** Your job here is to widen what they've considered, not narrow it to your preference. 2. **This is a starting point, not a ruling.** A score is a prompt for a conversation. 3. **Don't do it all at once.** These are several conversations spread over months.

**A practical note:** there's a separate short version written directly to them rather than about them — it should have come alongside this document. Send them that one. This document is for you.

One more thing, specific to law. This is the profile where the financial question matters most. Law school is expensive, and the debt is priced on assumptions about the graduate job market that have shifted in the last three years. That deserves a real conversation, not an optimistic one.

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## The short answer

**Law still leads somewhere valuable — but the old bargain has broken.** Survive three expensive years, grind through document review, emerge a lawyer. **That deal assumed the**

document-review years would exist to grind through, and increasingly they don't.

Trial advocacy scores 4.5. Junior associate and document-review work scores 7.9 — the widest internal split of any licensed profession we measure, and the fastest-moving score in the entire index.

Meanwhile legal employment in the United States hit a ten-year high in early 2026. Both of those things are true at once, and understanding why is the whole of this document.

## The scores

| TRACK                               | 2023 | 2025 | FALL 2026 | 3-YR MOVEMENT | BAND          |
|-------------------------------------|------|------|-----------|---------------|---------------|
| Trial litigator / advocacy          | 3.8  | 4.1  | 4.5       | +0.7          | Low–Moderate  |
| Regulatory & compliance counsel     | 4.1  | 4.5  | 5.0       | +0.9          | Moderate      |
| In-house counsel                    | 4.3  | 4.8  | 5.2       | +0.9          | Moderate      |
| Transactional / corporate associate | 5.1  | 5.7  | 6.3       | +1.2          | Moderate–High |
| Junior associate / document review  | 6.0  | 7.2  | 7.9       | +1.9          | High          |

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, bedside nursing scores 2.8, and entry-level software development scores 8.1.

**Read the table this way:** the split is 3.4 points wide, and it falls almost exactly along the line of who is personally answerable for something. Same bar card, same law school, sometimes the same firm. What differs is whether the work is producing documents or standing behind a decision.

## Why law scores the way it does — the six factors

We score every profession in this index against the same six questions, with the same weights. Here's how a junior associate answers them — the exposed end of the profession, and the end most graduates start at.

## HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

**More than almost any other licensed work we score.**

First-pass document review. Contract analysis and comparison. Legal research and case retrieval. First-draft memos and correspondence. Due diligence and discovery sorting. Standard filings.

That list is not a forecast. It is a description of what large firms have already automated, and it happens to be an almost complete description of what a first-year associate was hired to do in 2019.

What resists: standing up in a courtroom, being the person a client trusts with an existential problem, judgment on a genuinely novel question, and holding the bar card and the liability that comes with it.

## HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

**This is law's crisis, and it is worse than the automation itself.**

The tasks AI absorbed first were the billable grunt work firms used to sell — and, not coincidentally, the work through which associates built judgment by repetition. When those tasks vanish, the profession stays healthy while the route into it narrows.

Only 38% of 2025 associate hires came directly from graduating classes, down from 46% two years earlier, while lateral hiring of experienced lawyers rose. Firms are buying judgment rather than building it.

Paralegal hiring at the largest firms has fallen sharply since 2018, and a large share of paralegal tasks are automatable with current technology.

## DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

**Almost none of it, and this is law's structural weakness.**

Legal work is text in, text out. There is no physical component to protect it, which is why software and law — two professions with almost nothing else in common — score so similarly at the junior end.

The exception is the courtroom, and that exception is doing a great deal of work in this profile.

## DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

**At the senior end, absolutely. At the junior end, barely at all.**

A client facing an existential problem wants a human advocate who owns the outcome. Someone must be professionally answerable when advice turns out to be wrong.

But a junior associate produces work that someone else signs. No client knows their name, no professional obligation attaches to them individually, and nobody is relying on them personally. The protection in law is real, and it has to be earned rather than inherited from the profession.

**DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)**

**Comprehensively — but read the next section carefully, because this factor behaves differently in law than anywhere else in the index.**

**HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)**

**For a litigator, constantly. For a document reviewer, rarely.**

Advocacy involves an opponent actively trying to be unpredictable, which is a form of novelty no pattern-matching system handles well. Reviewing forty thousand documents against a defined set of criteria is the opposite.

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## The bar card protects acts, not people

This deserves its own section, because it is the single most misunderstood thing about law's exposure — and because the lesson generalizes well beyond this profession.

Licensing is normally the most durable protection we score. It moves at the speed of legislation rather than technology, and no advance in capability repeals a scope-of-practice rule.

Law has it in full. Only a barred attorney can appear, advise and sign. That is why trial advocacy rates 9.5 on the regulatory factor and sits comfortably in the low band.

**But protection attaches to acts, not to people.**

The bar card protects the appearance in court, the signed advice, the fiduciary relationship. It does not protect the reading of forty thousand documents. Nothing in any statute says a human must perform first-pass discovery review — so nothing prevented that work from being automated the moment the technology was adequate, which it now is.

This is why a junior associate rates only 7.0 on licensing rather than 9.5. They hold the same qualification as the partner. The license simply doesn't reach the work they're doing.

**Compare nursing, where the licence does something law's does not: it mandates the training hours themselves.** A nursing student cannot qualify without supervised clinical practice, so the on-ramp is written into law. Law reserves the courtroom and the signature and leaves the apprenticeship entirely exposed.

The general lesson: ask what a licence actually reserves, and whether it reserves the training as well as the practice. Those are different protections, and the second matters far more to someone entering the field.

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## What the trend shows

We retrospectively scored law for 2023 and 2025 using this same methodology. Unlike most professions in this index, two factors moved rather than one — and that is the story.

**Junior associate: 6.0 → 7.2 → 7.9.** Up 1.9 points in three years — the fastest-moving score anywhere in this index, ahead of entry-level software development.

**Trial litigator: 3.8 → 4.1 → 4.5.** Up 0.7. Real movement, but a third of the pace.

**The gap widened from 2.2 points to 3.4.** Like software, law isn't sinking. It's splitting.

**What moved.** Automatability rose as document review, research and drafting were absorbed. But entry-path erosion rose in parallel — and that second movement is the one that matters, because it reflects firms changing their hiring behavior rather than technology changing its capability.

**What didn't move.** The physical factor sat at 1.0 throughout — law has never had that protection and hasn't acquired any. Regulatory protection for the senior end held completely steady.

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## How durable is the protection?

Every "AI can't do X" boundary has proved temporary. So the useful question isn't whether law's protections hold today, but how long each is likely to last.

| PROTECTION                          | STRENGTH TODAY         | DURABILITY             | WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM                                                                                |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Regulatory / licensing</b>       | Strong, but narrow     | <b>Most durable</b>    | Moves at the speed of legislation. But it reserves specific acts, and unreserved work is unprotected regardless. |
| <b>Human trust / accountability</b> | Strong at senior level | <b>Durable</b>         | Clients in serious trouble want a human advocate who owns the outcome. Socially and legally rooted.              |
| <b>Judgment under novelty</b>       | Strong in advocacy     | <b>Eroding, slowly</b> | Adversarial novelty resists automation better than complexity does — an opponent is paid to be unpredictable.    |
| <b>Physical / embodied</b>          | Effectively none       | n/a                    | Except the courtroom. Law has no physical shelter and never has.                                                 |

**The honest read.** Law's two real protections — the reserved act and personal accountability — are both durable. They are also both senior attributes. A graduate has neither, and the traditional route to acquiring them is the part being compressed.

## How the role will actually change

Not "will law exist" — it will. The useful question is what a legal career looks like in ten years.

| WAS THE JOB                       | IS BECOMING THE JOB                                                                |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Reviewing the documents           | Directing the review, then checking the exceptions                                 |
| Researching the point of law      | Verifying the research and judging whether it applies here                         |
| Drafting the memo                 | Editing a machine-generated draft                                                  |
| Learning by repetition over years | Learning by supervision — which teaches differently, and nobody yet knows how well |
| Billing hours for volume          | Billing for judgment, which changes firm economics substantially                   |

**Two consequences worth naming.**



*The training question.* Previous generations built judgment by drafting fifty discovery responses badly and being corrected. Associates now edit machine-generated drafts instead. Faster — but whether it trains as well is genuinely unknown, and the profession has noticed. Some firms are now deliberately reserving work for manual completion purely to preserve its training value. Firms do not sacrifice efficiency for sentiment.

*The billing question.* Law's economics were built on selling hours of junior time. When those hours stop being billable, the business model shifts — and how firms respond will determine graduate hiring more than the technology will.

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## Human strengths that will matter most

Ranked by how well each resists the coming decade, specific to law:

1. **Advocacy under adversarial pressure** — persuading a person, reading a room, responding to an opponent who is actively trying to surprise you. The hardest thing here to replicate. 2. **Accountability** — being the barred human who signs, appears and answers. Durable, legally rooted, and the reason a qualified person stays in the loop. 3. **Client trust in a crisis** — being the person someone calls when their company or their liberty is at stake. 4. **Judgment on genuine novelty** — the unprecedented question, the case with thin authority and high consequence. 5. **Verification and discernment** — knowing when a machine-generated draft or research result is subtly, confidently wrong. A new core skill and barely taught anywhere.

Notably absent: speed of research, volume of drafting, and breadth of recalled authority. These were the traditional markers of a strong junior lawyer and are the fastest-depreciating.

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## Other things to consider about this job

Everything above measures one thing: how exposed law is to AI. It says nothing about whether the work is rewarding, whether the training is survivable, or who this suits.

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## What's genuinely good about it

**The work at the top of this profession is genuinely excellent.** Advocacy, complex advisory and high-stakes negotiation are intellectually demanding in a way few careers are, and practitioners describe them in terms much closer to craft than to process.



What lawyers report as rewarding is consistent:

- **Advocacy itself** — representing someone whose interests genuinely depend on you doing it well
- **Intellectual difficulty** — law rewards precision of thought in a way that keeps being interesting
- **Variety of practice** — few qualifications open onto so many genuinely different working lives
- **Autonomy at senior level**, including realistic routes to partnership or independent practice
- **Portability of the skill set**, even where the qualification itself doesn't transfer

**The practical case:** senior earnings are strong, the profession is expanding in aggregate, and demand for regulatory and compliance expertise is growing in every heavily-regulated industry.

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## What's genuinely hard about it

The biggest risks to a legal career are the debt and the hours, not the automation.

**The debt — and the thing almost nobody explains about law salaries.**

Georgetown's Center on Education and the Workforce found that median earnings *net of debt payments* four years after graduation are **\$72,000** across all law school graduates. At seven schools they exceed \$200,000. At 33 law schools, graduates earn less than \$55,000 net of debt four years out.

The critical detail is that **law salaries are bimodal, not normally distributed**. Around half of graduates start between \$60,000 and \$85,000, while roughly a quarter start between \$215,000 and \$225,000 — and almost nobody sits in the middle. This means the "median starting salary" figure schools quote describes almost no actual graduate.

Median debt runs around \$155,000 at the most selective schools, \$125,000 at top-50 schools and \$95,000 at regional ones — against median starting salaries of roughly \$190,000, \$140,000 and \$85,000 respectively. Bar passage tracks the same line: 91% first-time passage at schools where net earnings exceed \$100,000, against 59% at schools where they fall below \$55,000.

**The practical consequence:** which law school someone attends affects the financial outcome far more than it does in most professions, and the gap is widening rather than closing.

**The hours.** Billable-hour culture at large firms remains demanding, and it is demanding during exactly the years many people are forming families.

**Attrition and wellbeing.** This is well documented rather than anecdotal. The ABA and Hazelden Betty Ford Foundation surveyed nearly 13,000 practising attorneys for a study published in the *Journal of Addiction Medicine*, and found 21% screening positive for problematic drinking, 28% for depression and 19% for anxiety — substantially above general-population rates.

The same study found the risk was highest among **junior lawyers and those in the first decade of practice**, which overturned the previous assumption that the problem accumulated with seniority. The profession now treats this as an occupational risk rather than a character failing, and anyone entering should know it.

**The entry bottleneck.** Covered in detail above, but it belongs in this list too: getting in is harder than it was, and the traditional path is narrower.

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## Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Law tends to suit people who:

- **Enjoy argument as a craft** rather than as conflict — the distinction matters enormously
- **Are precise by temperament.** Law rewards exactness and punishes approximation.
- **Can hold an opposing position in mind** clearly enough to argue against it
- **Tolerate being wrong in public** — being corrected by judges, opponents and colleagues, throughout a career
- **Are comfortable with responsibility for someone else's outcome**

Equally honest about who finds it hard:

- People who **avoid conflict** will find advocacy draining rather than energizing
  - People who need **closure and certainty** — much of law is ambiguous and stays that way
  - People drawn primarily by **status or parental expectation**, who are over-represented among those who leave
  - People who want **predictable hours** in the first decade
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## What else is moving this market

The AI score measures task exposure. It cannot see the profession's economics — and in law those are moving as much as the technology.

**Aggregate employment is strong.** Legal employment in the United States hit a ten-year high in early 2026, and large firms posted record revenues. A healthy profession with a compressed entry pyramid is not a contradiction — it is precisely the pattern our entry-path factor exists to capture.

**Regulatory complexity is a tailwind.** Every new regulatory regime — data, AI, environmental, financial — creates work that requires accountable human advice. This is genuine and growing.

**Law school economics are the pressure point.** Applications, tuition and debt loads move independently of AI, and they determine who can realistically enter far more than automation does.

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## The strongest argument against our score

We think it deserves a proper hearing rather than a footnote.

**The argument:** cutting junior hiring is a self-defeating industry mistake, not a permanent structural shift. Every senior lawyer was once a junior, and there is no alternative factory producing experienced ones. On this view, firms gutting their entry pipelines are cannibalizing their own future, and will be forced to correct course when the senior shortage arrives in five to seven years. Today's squeeze is a painful cycle, not a new normal — and our entry-erosion factor is overweighting a temporary condition.

The evidence for it is real. Aggregate legal employment is at a ten-year high. Some firms are already reserving work for manual completion specifically to preserve training value.

**Where we land, and why we hold the score anyway.** The logic is sound, but the market isn't following it. The pipeline argument has been made loudly and publicly by senior industry voices for over two years, and graduate hiring data has moved the other way throughout. Whatever firms should do for their long-term health, what they are doing is optimizing for this quarter — and a graduate lives in the hiring reality, not the hiring theory.

The gap between the rational strategy and the observed behavior is itself the thing to watch, because it can close in two very different ways: firms rediscovering junior hiring (the score falls), or firms deciding AI closes the seniority gap faster than apprenticeship does (the score climbs further).

**We don't know which way it breaks.** This is a named open question we'll revisit every edition. If graduate hiring rebounds, our entry-path score comes down and we'll say so plainly. Until the data turns, we score the market as it is rather than as it ought to be.

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## The AI-native advantage — what to actually do about it

**The situation, factually:** AI is thoroughly embedded in legal practice already. Firms are redesigning what a first-year is for — directing AI through research and drafting, then evaluating and communicating the output. Some now test this explicitly in final-round interviews.

**That gap is the opportunity.** The tools are deployed. The people who can genuinely direct and verify them are not.

### FIRST, A WORD ABOUT HOW SCHOOLS FRAME THIS

Most of what a student hears about AI at school is about cheating. Those rules exist for good reason — using AI to skip the reasoning genuinely leaves you weaker, and in law that eventually becomes a professional-negligence problem rather than a grades problem.

But that framing treats AI as a temptation to be resisted rather than a technology to be understood. Those are different things, and only one is relevant to a career.

### WHAT AN AI-NATIVE LAWYER ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE

**1. Verify.** Knowing when a generated research result or draft is confidently wrong. In law this is the most consequential version of the skill anywhere in this index, and the evidence is unambiguous.

A public database maintained by researcher Damien Charlotin has documented around 1,600 court proceedings worldwide in which AI-fabricated citations or content were submitted to a court — up from roughly 200 a year earlier. Penalties have escalated sharply: the first widely reported case in 2023 drew a \$5,000 fine, while in March 2026 a Sixth Circuit panel ordered two attorneys to pay \$15,000 each plus the opposing party's appellate fees, and by mid-2026 courts had begun suspending lawyers and cancelling trials over it.

The pattern in every case is identical: a lawyer signed a citation they had not read. The verification skill only works on top of legal knowledge you actually built yourself.

**2. Direct.** Framing a research or drafting task precisely enough to get usable output. This is a genuine skill and firms are now testing for it.

**3. Judge relevance.** Knowing whether an authority actually applies to *these* facts — the thing a system retrieving text cannot do.

**4. Explain and own.** Being the person who signs, and who can explain to a client or a court why the answer is right.

**5. Contribute.** Firms are rebuilding their processes around these tools and need people who can say whether something works in practice.

#### CONCRETE PREPARATION, BY STAGE

**Before law school:** use the general tools enough to develop instinct for where they fabricate — law is the field where confident invention is most dangerous and most easily demonstrated. Ask law schools how AI appears in the curriculum; the answers will differ enormously.

**During the degree:** treat legal technology and e-discovery as real subjects. On placement, notice what the firm actually uses and where senior lawyers override it. Practise the verification habit deliberately.

**Entering the profession:** ask about AI tooling and training at interview. Volunteer for the process-redesign work — firms need practitioner voices and rarely have enough.

#### WHY THIS IS AN ADVANTAGE

A newly qualified lawyer who is genuinely fluent stands out immediately against colleagues with decades more experience — not on legal skill, which takes years, but on a dimension where seniority confers no advantage. In a profession where advancement is famously time-served, that is an unusual opening.

**And it is protective, not just advantageous.** Look at the score table. The gap between 4.5 and 7.9 is a gap in *accountability and judgment* — and AI fluency is part of what moves someone toward the judgment side of that line rather than the executional side.

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# The routes in — they're not all the same

| ROUTE                                 | TYPICAL LENGTH      | NOTES                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Undergraduate law degree              | 3–4 years           | Standard in most of the world outside the US. Followed by professional training.                                                                                                              |
| Graduate-entry law (JD or conversion) | 3 years post-degree | The US standard. Also common elsewhere for career-changers.                                                                                                                                   |
| Apprenticeship / trainee routes       | 5–6 years           | Available in some jurisdictions. Earn while qualifying, no tuition debt. Worth investigating seriously given the debt picture — these routes are expanding while the traditional one narrows. |
| Paralegal to qualified                | Varies              | Longer and less certain, but real. Note that paralegal work itself scores poorly.                                                                                                             |
| In-house and regulatory routes        | Post-qualification  | Where much of the protected work now sits.                                                                                                                                                    |

**The thing to check locally:** how graduates from a specific school actually enter the profession, and in what proportion. This varies far more than schools advertise.

## Where a law degree can take them later

Law is unusually portable as a way of thinking, even where the qualification doesn't transfer.

- **Advocacy and litigation** — the most protected practice
- **Regulatory and compliance** — growing in every regulated industry, and accountability-heavy
- **In-house counsel** — commercial judgment embedded in a business
- **Policy and government** — legislative drafting, regulation, public service
- **Business and management** — legal training is a common route into commercial leadership
- **Legal technology** — the people who understand both practice and the systems are exactly who firms need
- **Academia, journalism, compliance, risk, and dispute resolution**



**The caveat that runs through this index applies here:** the further a role sits from personal accountability for an outcome, the more its exposure climbs. Move deliberately rather than by drift.

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## What to look for in a law school

- 1. Where do graduates actually work in year one — and doing what?** Not "employed." Not "in the legal sector." Practising, and in what role. This is the single most important number and the one most schools are vaguest about.
  - 2. Practical advocacy and clinical experience.** Moot courts, legal clinics, real client work under supervision. If the market supplies fewer training years, the degree has to supply more.
  - 3. Is the curriculum AI-native?** Are students taught to use legal AI tools *and* to verify them? A school that bans them is training for a job that no longer exists; one that teaches them uncritically is worse.
  - 4. Employer relationships that are real.** Named firms, actual placement pipelines, and honest data about who converts.
  - 5. The debt-to-outcome ratio.** Total cost against realistic first-job earnings for *that* school's graduates, not the national average.
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## Questions to ask a law school

**On outcomes — the ones that matter most:**

- Of last year's graduates, what percentage were working as practising lawyers within nine months?
- How has that number changed over the last three years?
- What are graduates who didn't enter practice doing instead?

**On practical training:**

- How much supervised client or advocacy work does a typical student do?
- What proportion of students secure a training position or clerkship, and when?

**On AI:**



- How does the curriculum prepare students to work with legal AI tools?
- Where do students learn to identify incorrect machine-generated research?
- Has the curriculum changed in the last two years? What specifically?

#### On cost:

- What is the total cost including living expenses, and what is the median debt at graduation?
- What is the median first-job salary for your graduates?

**Red flags:** outcomes quoted only as "employed"; no clinical or advocacy programme; a curriculum unchanged since 2022; reluctance to discuss debt-to-salary ratios.

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## Go deeper — further reading

#### The evidence:

- **AI Reshapes the Entry-Level Pipeline Across Law, Finance, and Consulting** — Tech Times, covering FT reporting. Documents structural redesign rather than simple cuts: firms rebuilding what a first-year is for. Also contains the paradox worth sitting with — legal employment at a ten-year high even as first-pass document review automated.
- **Senior Lawyers Lead New Law Firm Hiring Boom** — JD Journal. The entry-path erosion in numbers: only 38% of 2025 associate hires came directly from graduating classes, down from 46%, while lateral hires accounted for 49%.
- **AI, Legal Tech, and the Hiring Gap Law Firms Didn't Plan For** — Prime Legal Staffing. The best articulation of the training problem rather than the hiring problem, including the striking detail that some firms now reserve work for manual completion to preserve its training value.
- **A Law Degree Is No Sure Thing** — Georgetown University Center on Education and the Workforce. The primary source for the debt figures above, ranking 186 law schools by graduate earnings net of debt. If you read one thing before committing money to law school, read this — it is the clearest demonstration that the school matters financially far more than the degree does.
- **The Prevalence of Substance Use and Other Mental Health Concerns Among American Attorneys** — Journal of Addiction Medicine, via Harvard Center on the Legal Profession. The

peer-reviewed ABA/Hazelden study of nearly 13,000 attorneys behind the wellbeing figures above, including the counterintuitive finding that risk is highest early in a career rather than late.

- **AI Hallucination Cases: the sanctions tracker** — the running count of court proceedings involving AI-fabricated citations, built on Damien Charlotin's database. Useful for seeing the penalty curve rather than a single anecdote.

**The counterargument — read this one:**

- **Will AI Replace Lawyers? The 2026 Data** — *Higher Landing*.

The strongest challenge to our 7.9 junior score is the employment data itself: legal employment at a ten-year high, large firms posting record revenues. If AI were gutting the profession, that is not what the aggregate numbers would look like. The argument runs that legal demand is expanding fast enough to absorb the efficiency gains — firms do more work with the same people rather than the same work with fewer — and that what looks like displacement is redistribution.

**Where we land:** we think both things are true, and that's exactly why we score tracks rather than professions. Total legal employment can rise while the first rung narrows — the same source notes paralegal hiring at the 250 largest firms fell 26% since 2018 and estimates around 69% of paralegal tasks are automatable. A healthy profession with a compressed entry pyramid is precisely the pattern our entry-path factor exists to capture. But if aggregate strength eventually pulls entry hiring back up, our score should fall, and we'll report it when the graduate-hire share starts climbing rather than falling.

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## Bottom line

Law is not dying. It is splitting — and more sharply than any other licensed profession we measure.

**The protected end is genuinely protected.** Advocacy, regulatory counsel and in-house judgment are shielded by two of the most durable things in our framework: a reserved act and personal accountability. Those aren't going anywhere.

**The entry end is the problem, and it's a real one.** The traditional route into law ran through exactly the work that has been automated, and firms are now buying experience rather than building it. The profession is expanding while its base narrows.

**So the useful advice isn't "avoid law."** It's: understand that the destination determines almost everything, interrogate a school's real first-year outcomes rather than its employment rate, take the debt question seriously with actual numbers, and look hard at apprenticeship or earn-while-you-qualify routes if they exist where you are.

And it's worth restating what the risk analysis can't measure. Advocacy — representing someone whose interests genuinely depend on you doing it well — is among the more meaningful things a person can do for a living, and lawyers who do it describe it as craft rather than process. The difficulties above are real. So is that.

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## Discussion questions

*To work through together, after you've both read this.*

### Part 1 — About the work itself

1. What made law appealing in the first place? Get underneath "I like arguing" or "it's a good career" to something specific. 2. When you picture them doing this job, what does a Tuesday look like? Compare pictures. 3. Do they want to be in a courtroom, or advising a business, or shaping policy? Those are genuinely different careers wearing the same qualification. 4. Which part of the job do they think they'd like least? 5. Do they enjoy argument as a craft, or do they find conflict draining? The distinction matters more here than anywhere.

### Part 2 — Reacting to the findings

6. Was anything here surprising? Which part, and why? 7. Trial advocacy scores 4.5 and junior document review 7.9. Does that change how they think about where they'd want to end up? 8. The profile says the bar card protects acts, not people. Did that land — and can they apply it to another career they're considering? 9. Legal employment is at a ten-year high while the entry route narrows. How do they make sense of those two facts together?

### Part 2b — The harder conversation

10. **The debt.** Have you both actually run the numbers — total cost, realistic first-job earnings, years to repay — or has it been assumed? 11. What happens if they graduate and don't get a training position? Is there a plan, or is law the only plan? 12. The profession has persistently high rates of burnout and substance misuse. Does that change anything for them, and do they

know why it's true? 13. Billable-hour culture through their late twenties and thirties. Have they pictured that concretely?

## **Part 2c — The other side**

14. Of what lawyers say is rewarding — advocacy, intellectual difficulty, variety, autonomy — which two matter most to them? 15. Looking at "who this work suits": which items sound like them, honestly? Which don't? Answer separately, then compare. 16. Can they hold an opposing position in mind well enough to argue against it? That's the core aptitude and it's testable.

## **Part 2d — The AI question, practically**

17. Of the five AI-native capabilities — verify, direct, judge relevance, explain and own, contribute — which sounds most interesting? Which hardest? 18. Courts have sanctioned lawyers for filing AI-generated citations to cases that don't exist. What does that tell them about what the job now requires?

## **Part 3 — Testing it against reality**

19. **The most valuable single action here:** find a working lawyer — ideally not a family friend who'll be encouraging — for an honest half-hour. Ask them:

- How did you get in, and would that route still work today? - What are the trainees and first-years on your team doing, and how is that different from when you started? - What do you wish someone had told you before law school?

20. Can they sit in on a court hearing? Public galleries are open, it costs nothing, and it demolishes a lot of assumptions in an afternoon.

## **Part 4 — About the school**

21. Ask each school the outcome questions from section 15 and compare. The evasiveness is as informative as the numbers. 22. What's the total cost, and what's the median first-job salary for that school's graduates? 23. Are there apprenticeship or earn-while-qualifying routes available where you are?

## **Part 5 — Widening the frame**

24. If law weren't available, what's the closest thing they'd choose? The answer usually reveals what they're actually drawn to. 25. Do they want law, or what law is made of? Someone drawn

to it may be drawn to advocacy, to precision, to status, to argument, or to helping people in trouble — and those lead to genuinely different places, some of them cheaper and shorter.

## Part 6 — For the parent, alone

26. Am I hoping they pick this? If so, is that reason about them or about me? 27. Law carries status that other good careers don't. How much of my enthusiasm is about that? 28. Am I comfortable with the debt if it doesn't work out as planned? 29. What's the one thing I most want them to understand — and can I say it in a sentence, without a number in it?

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*This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation, not a guarantee or a prediction. Where the evidence is contested we've said so, where our own score is challenged we've flagged it, and where we might be wrong we've linked to the people making the opposite case.*

*Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology, not archived from published editions. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.*